



DAVID SHAW
JANUARY 11TH, 2023



l'abeille is a 54 seat French restaurant located at 412 Greenwich Street on a classic Tribeca cobblestone street corner. The restaurant is centered on a six-course prix-fixe menu but also provides a rotating selection of seasonal a-la-carte dishes with a strong wine and cocktail program. l'abeille is the brainchild of Chef Mitsunobu Nagae, a veteran Michelin-starred chef who has worked at multiple legendary restaurants in Tokyo, Paris, and New York. Chef Mitsu was most recently the Chef de Cuisine at Shun in Midtown Manhattan.



MENU DÉGUSTATION

Royale de Foie Gras, Mousseline de Patate Douce, Porto
Foie Gras Royale, Japanese Satsumaimo Sweet Potato, Porto Wine

Crabe Royal de Norvège, Mousse de Noix de Coco, Fruit de la Passion, Radis Croquants
Norwegian King Crab, Coconut Mousse, Passion Fruit, Radish

Velouté de Topinambour, Noix de St-Jacques d'Hokkaido, Truffe Noire d'Hiver
Sunchoke Velouté, Scallop from Hokkaido, Périgord Black Winter Truffle

Filet de Maquereau Espagnol Grillé, Sucrine, Crème de Coquillages au Curcuma
Grilled Spanish Mackerel, Gem Lettuce, Shellfish and Turmeric Sauce

Selle de Chevreuil Rôtie de Nouvelle-Zélande, Salsifis Caramélisés, Noisette, Airelles, Sauce au Porto
Roasted Venison Saddle from New Zealand, Caramelized Salsify, Hazelnut, Huckleberry, Porto Wine Sauce

Sorbet au Kiwi, Mousseline au Lait, Citron Vert, Huile d'Olive
Kiwi Sorbet, Milk Mousseline, Lime, Olive Oil

Mont-Blanc aux Marrons, Crème Glacée au Sucre “Wasanbon”
Chestnut Mont-Blanc, “Wasanbon” Sugar Ice Cream

Chocolat Blanc et Fleur d’Oranger, Glace au Miel
White Chocolate and Orange Blossom, Burnt Honey Ice Cream

Galette des Rois à la Frangipane, Financiers à la Pistache
King's Pie with Almond Frangipane, Pistachio Financiers



The first dish on the degustation menu is a foie gras dish with port wine and Japanese sweet potato. The classic combination of foie gras and port wine reminds me of the amuse bouche at L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon. Considering chef Nagae's apprentice background, it's logical to guess that he may get inspiration from there. The addition of the sweet potato mousse, however, is a crowning touch to the foie gras dish. The sweet potato not only highlights chef Nagae's Japanese background as its one of the most important ingredients in Japanese cuisine, but it also adds a dreamy mellow sweetness and refined creamy texture to the combination. A chip of crispy sweet potato further introduces another layer of texture to the whole. The whole dish might be even better if served warm.



The January menu is a slight alternation from the December menu, and the only change is this crab dish substitute for the beef tartare. Using passionfruit and coconut to enliven the Norwegian king crab, chef Nagae is probably thinking of adding a southeastern Asia twist to the dish. Notwithstanding, the lack of flavor from both of the tropical fruits causes a very unpleasant flavor profile that is pale and awkward, resulting in the crab undulating between two irreconcilable points.



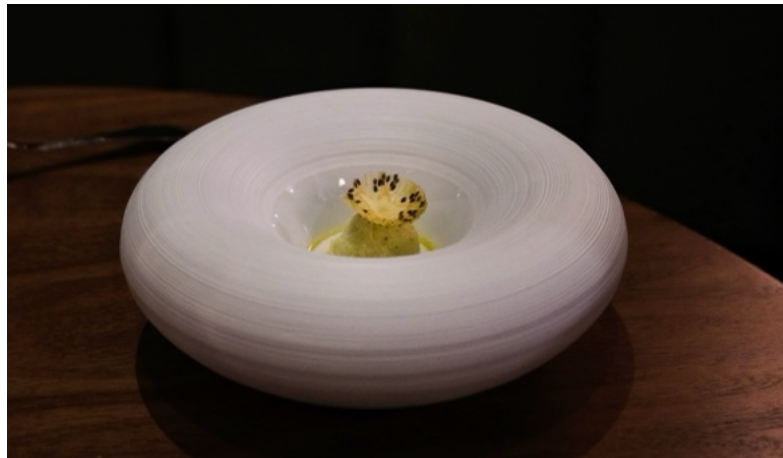
After two cold-served dishes, a warm soup finally shows up. The sunchoke velouté, a perfect choice for the winter menu, consists of a rich sunchoke soup base, half of a pan-seared scallop from Hokkaido, and some black winter truffle from Burgundy. As the core of the dish, the sunchoke velouté is prepared to perfection. With a rich but not overwhelmingly thick texture, the velouté reads complex and charming both on the mouth and nose. The Hokkaido scallop, though perfectly cooked, does not contribute much to the whole because of its tiny portion, and the black truffle also lacks certain depth and richness that fail to impress truffle lovers.



The main fish course is a rather interesting Spanish Mackerel dish, featuring the grilled fillet paired with a shellfish and turmeric sauce as well as gem lettuce and lettuce purée. While the fillet is slightly overcooked, the relatively dry flesh does not affect the untamed umami to shine through. As for the sauce, it is probably a shellfish béarnaise sauce with the addition of turmeric. The bright acidity and shellfish umami beautifully enliven the mackerel, while the turmeric ignites the whole with a punch of piquancy. The gem lettuce is directly cooked on the grill, and thus carries a gorgeous burning mark that both smells and tastes amazing. However, its combination with mackerel seems to be somehow not convincing.

The next venison dish marks the finale of the savory part. Centered on a beautiful cut of the venison saddle enwrapped in a hazelnut crust, the dish comprises caramelized salsify, huckleberry, and port wine sauce. While the venison on its own is cooked to perfection, other components might be somehow rough to enjoy. The caramelized salsify exhibits a daikon-like pureness with a light hint of bitterness, which is submerged by the extravagant richness of the port wine sauce, preventing the flavor of salsify to radiate. The huckleberry is also presented in a way that is not refined, as its sharp acidity does not combine well with other elements on the plate.





The seven-course menu is delightful enough to have a palate cleanser, yet the kiwi sorbet fails to bring freshness to the palate. A refreshing combination like this is ruined by its heavy texture. The sorbet is way too condense, adding another burden for the tongue and leaving no room for both the kiwi and lime to exhibit refreshing aromas.



Moving on to the mont-blanc dessert. The wasanbon ice cream oozing burned honey aroma is quite a delight to enjoy, whereas the chestnut part is not so much of a source of pleasure. Not only is the chestnut cream too sweet, but the texture of the vacherin part does not go well with the chestnut topping. The chocolate sauce is also a mystery here, as it is too little to be anyhow contributing. The other classic dessert is rather a fabulous one to end the dinner with. The bright yet mellow honey aroma is playing a perfectly tuned duet with the bright citrusy tone of the orange. It is a marvelous dish full of intriguing tastes and contrasting textures.

As for the petit fours, both of the traditional French pastries are well executed. It is also definitely a surprise to have the right-in-season king's pie, filled with the heavenly almond frangipane.



